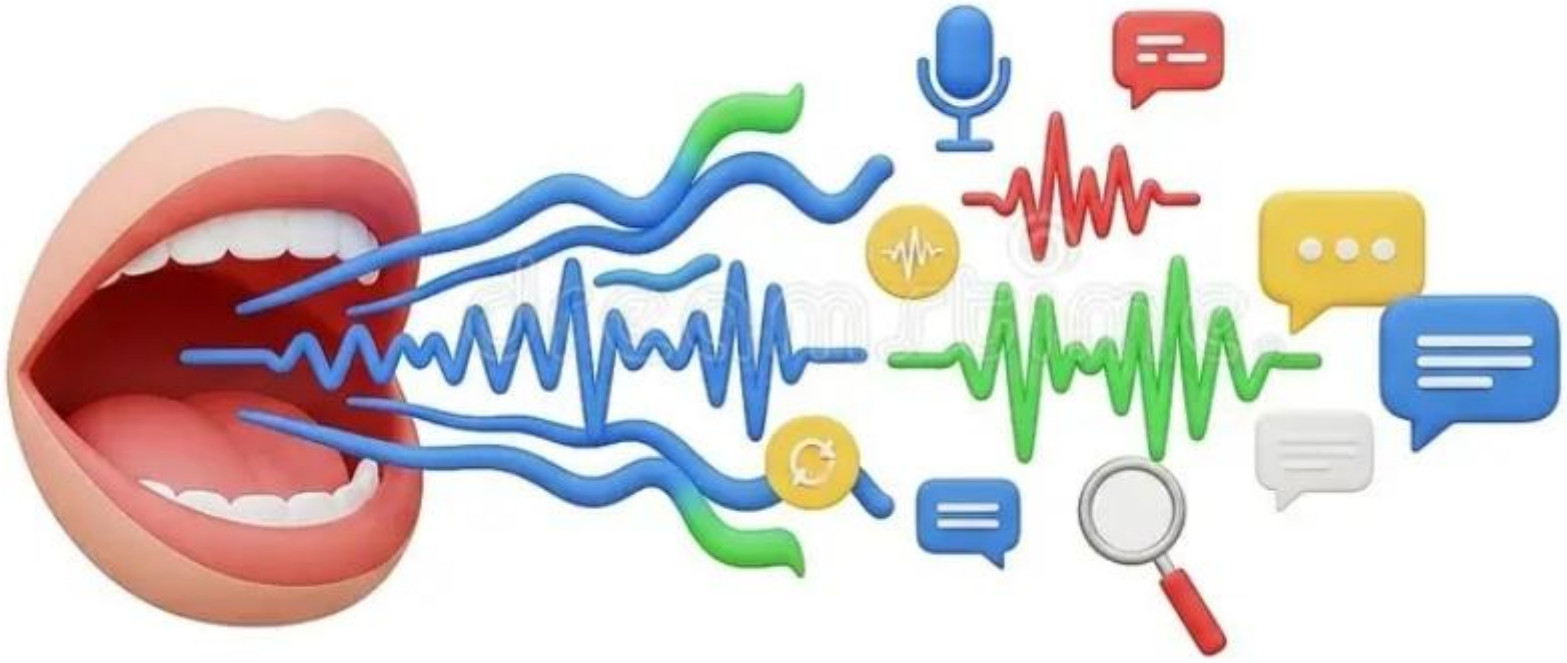
COLLEGE DE PARIS SUPERIEUR

Session 4: Pronunciation & Fluency

Bachelor 1 – Business English for IT Professionals



Dorcas Tchogoue

“The Final Test”

“You passed. But fluency is a habit, not a destination.”



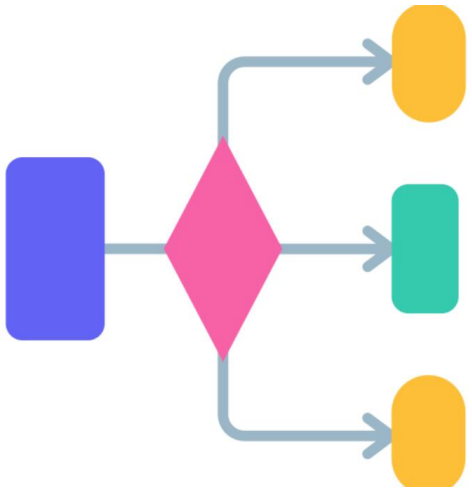
Session	Leo’s Problem	Solution
1	Didn’t understand business vocabulary	Learned key terms (deadline, stakeholder, touch base)
2	Sent a rude email + Reply All disaster	Learned email structure & tone
3	Presentation with 47 slides & 100 “um”s	Learned signposting & body language
4	Poor pronunciation & robot speech	Practiced stress, linking, & fluency

SESSION 4: Pronunciation & Fluency Techniques

Objectives:

- ❖ Identify and correct 3 common pronunciation errors for French speakers (/θ/).
- ❖Use sentence stress naturally to emphasize important words .
- ❖ Apply thought groups & pausing to sound more fluent and less robotic.
- ❖Distinguish between formal and casual reductions.
- ❖Use rising and falling intonation correctly for questions, lists, and statements.
- ❖Self-monitor pronunciation using recording and playback.

Goals



1) Every learner identifies their top 2 pronunciation challenges.
2) Every learner records and self-corrects one speaking sample.
3) Every learner leaves with practical techniques for continued improvement.

Why Pronunciation Matters for IT Pros

You can have perfect vocabulary, but if people can't understand you... it doesn't matter.

Discussion:

"Has anyone ever not understood you on a call? What happened?"

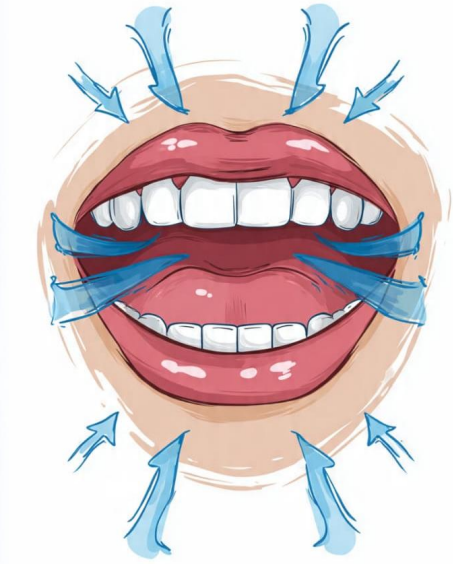


French Speakers' Top 5 Problem Sounds

1. /θ/ as in think, three, deadline (not "tink" or "sink")
2. /ð/ as in the, this, that
3. /h/ as in hello, have, help (not silent!)
4. Silent -e (final e in English is often silent: make, time, note)
5. ed endings (/t/, /d/, or /ɪd/ – walked, played, wanted)

Exercise: Listen and Repeat

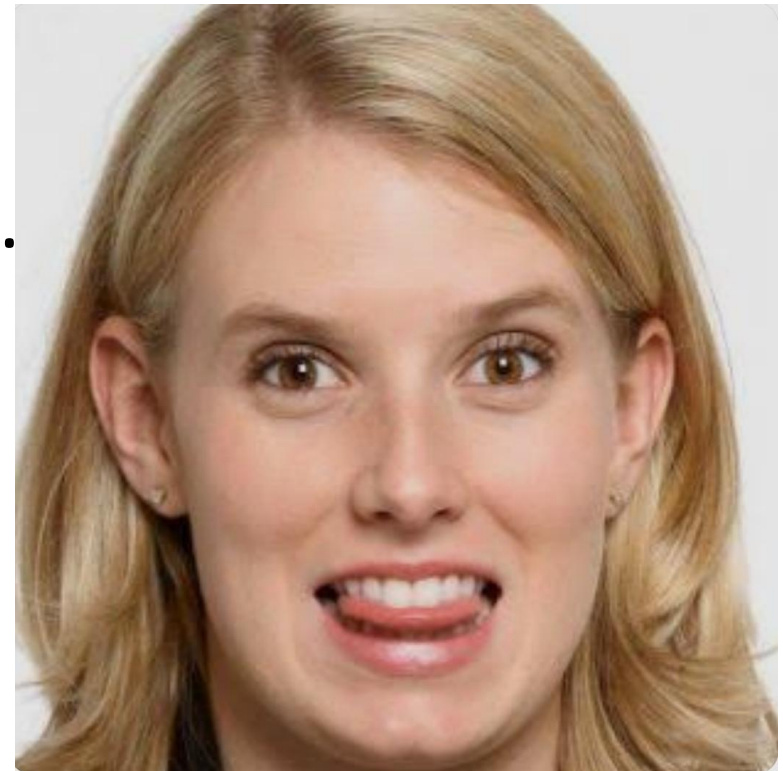
"Three things I think are thrilling."



Sound /θ/ – The Tongue Sandwich

Put your tongue between your teeth. Blow air.
- Practice words: think, thanks, three, month, deadline, both

Exercise:
Say "Thank you for the thoughtful thing" 5 times.



Sound /h/ – Don't Be Silent!

- Exhale strongly (not "'ello" but "hello")
- Practice words: hello, have, help, huge, behind, ahead
- Repeat: "How have you been? Happy to help!"

Exercise:

Say "How have you been?
Happy to help!"
– emphasize every H.



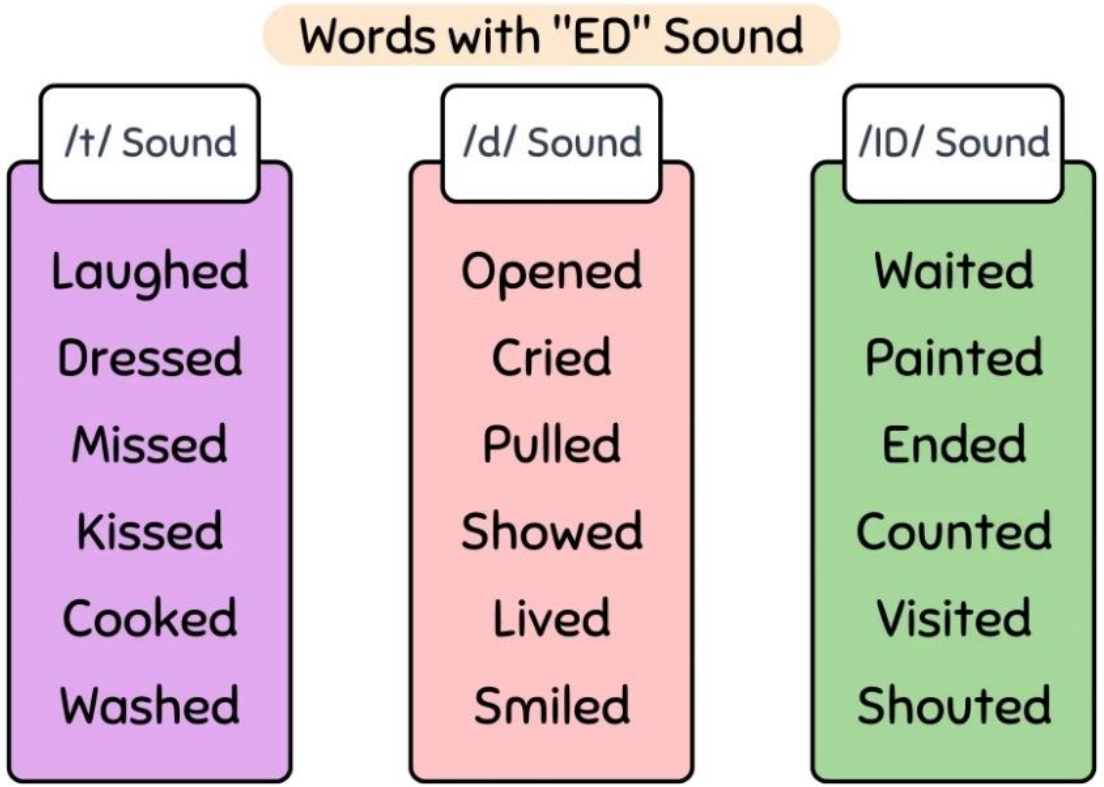
-ed Endings – 3 Ways to Say It

- /t/ after unvoiced sounds: walked, laughed, missed
- /d/ after voiced sounds: called, loved, changed
- /ɪd/ after T or D: wanted, needed, started

Exercise:

Sort these into /t/, /d/, /ɪd/:

fixed, ended, deployed, tested, used



Word Stress – Change the Meaning!

- REcord (noun – a file) vs. reCORD (verb – to capture)
- PREsent (gift) vs. preSENT (to show)



Exercise:

Say these pairs with correct stress:

- CONduct / conDUCT
- OBject / obJECT

Sentence Stress – Emphasize the Important Word

1. "**I** didn't delete the file." (Someone else did it)
2. "I **didn't** delete the file." (I am denying it strongly)
3. "I didn't **delete** the file." (I did something else to it)
4. "I didn't delete the **file**." (I deleted something else)

Exercise:

Say "I will finish the report on Friday"
with emphasis on different words.
How does meaning change?

Thought Groups
Stop Sounding Like a Robot

- Bad: No pauses –

  "We need to finish the sprint by Friday so let's work hard"
- Good: "We need to finish by Friday (pause) so let's work hard"

Exercise: Add pauses to:

"After the meeting I will send the report and then I will go home."

Linking Sounds
Make Sentences Flow

- "Get on" sounds like "Ge-ton"
- "Not at all" sounds like "No-ta-tall"
- "An apple" sounds like "A-napple"



Exercise:

Say "What are you waiting for?"
as one smooth phrase.

Intonation – Rising vs. Falling

- Rising (↗) for yes/no questions: "Are you coming?"
- Falling (↘) for statements/WH-questions: "Where are you going?"
  "I'm going home."

Exercise:

Say "You're done?" (rising – surprise) vs.
"You're done." (falling – statement).



Reductions – Gonna, Wanna, Gotta (When Okay?)

- OK for casual speech with colleagues: "I'm gonna send that email."
- NOT OK for formal/client presentations: "We're going to deploy on Friday."

Exercise: Change these to formal:

- "I gotta go"
- "Wanna meet?"
- "Gonna start now"

Casual or Formal?





Recording Lab – Listen to Yourself

- Record 1-minute business message on phone
- Listen back



Self-check questions:

- Do I drop H sounds?
- Do I pause?
- Is my stress correct?

Time: 10 minutes

Pair Work – Read This Email Aloud

"Dear team, the sprint deadline is Friday. Please update the budget and attach the UAT results. Let's touch base tomorrow."

❖ Partner writes down stress and pausing mistakes

Time: 10 minutes (swap roles)



Problem Sound Clinic – Your Choice

- "Which sound is hardest for you?" Then drills that sound as a group.
- Options: /θ/, /h/, -ed endings, word stress, intonation, linking.

Exercise:

Repeat challenging words
10 times as a class.

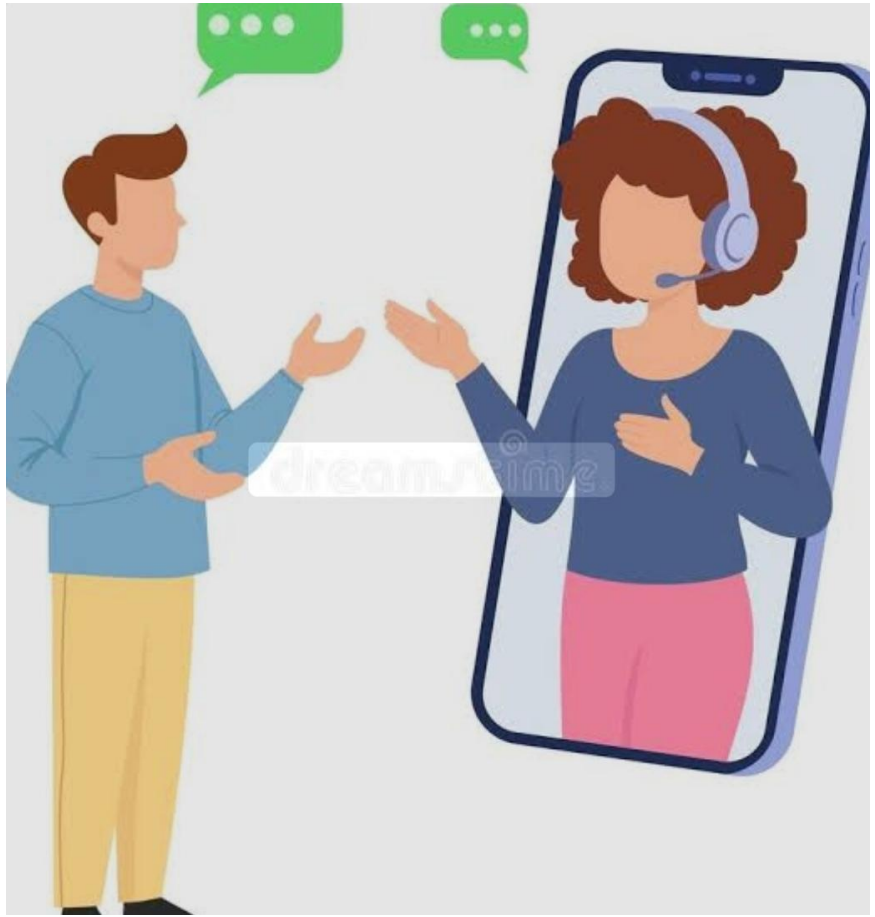


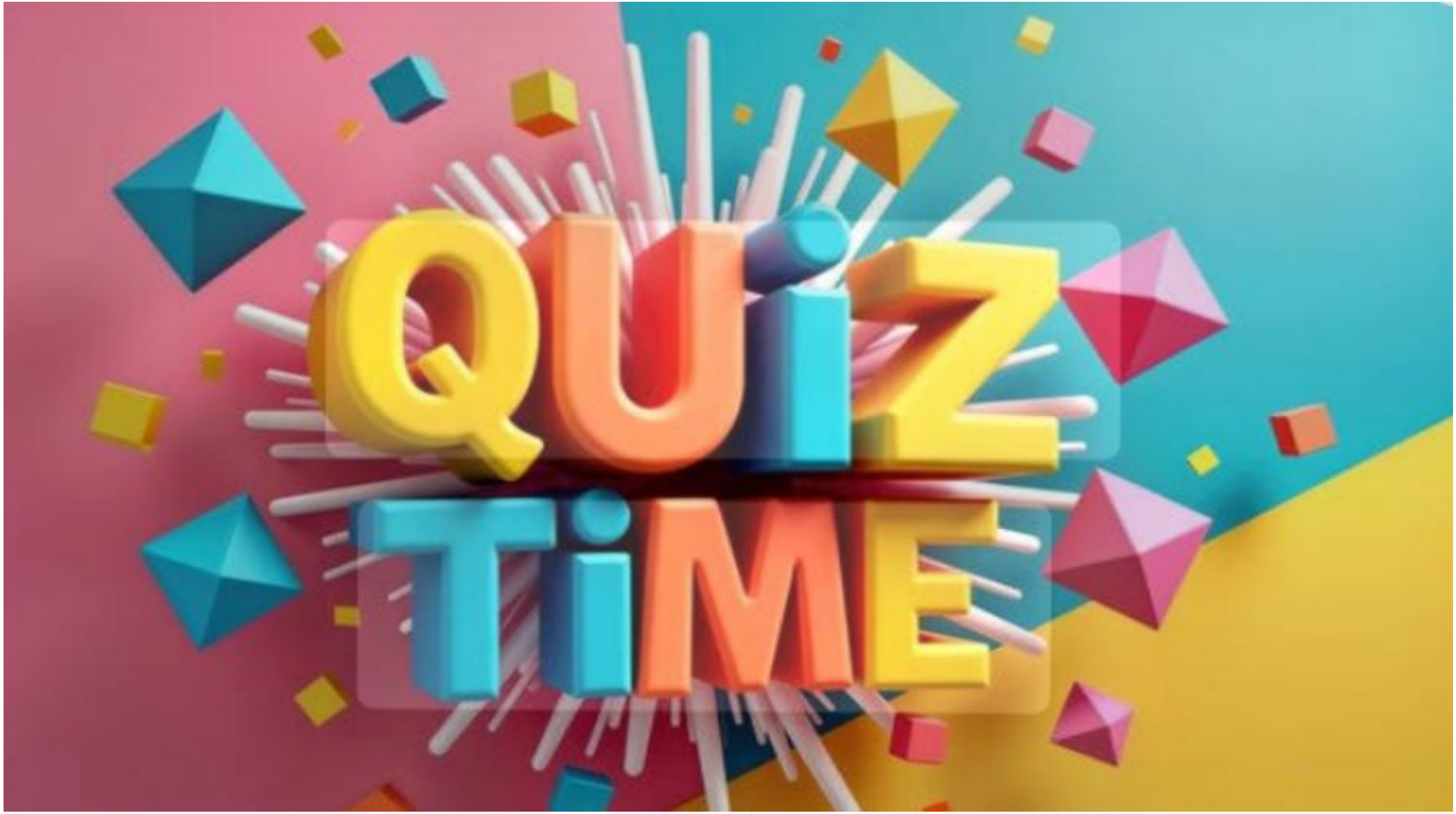
Fluency vs. Perfection – Good News!

- You don't need a perfect accent
- You need to be understood
- Native speakers make mistakes too

"You are already fluent enough.

Today is about polishing, not perfection."




QUIZ
TIME

1. For French speakers, which sound is often difficult because it requires putting your tongue between your teeth?

A) /h/ as in "hello"

B) /θ/ as in "think"

C) /d/ as in "dog"

D) /m/ as in "meeting"

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2. How many ways can you pronounce the "-ed" ending in English?

A) 1 way

B) 2 ways

C) 3 ways

D) 4 ways

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3. Which sentence has correct word stress for the word "record" as a NOUN?

A) reCORD

B) REcord

C) recORD

D) RECord

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4. "Gonna" is acceptable in which situation?

A) A formal email to a client

B) A presentation to the CEO

C) A casual conversation with a colleague

D) A written contract

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Final Practice – 2-Minute Improv

Topic: "My plan for next weekend" – but use business vocabulary!

(deadline, stakeholder, budget, touch base)

Funny example: "My stakeholder (wife) gave me a deadline to clean the garage. My budget is zero."

Time: 2 min per student
(just for laughs).



Course Review – Everything We Learned

Session 1:
15+ business words + false friends + expressions

Session 2:
Professional emails (structure, tone, disasters)

Session 3:
2-minute presentations + simplify jargon

Session 4:
Pronunciation (sounds, stress, pausing, intonation)

Review and Reflection

- What have you learned today?
- Share one thing you learned and how you will apply it





Some valuable resources:

Recommended Book

Title: English Pronunciation in Use – Intermediate (Cambridge)

Author: Mark Hancock

Relevant unit: Units 10–15 (Word stress, Sentence stress, Linking, Common problem sounds)

Why: Audio included (if you have CD or online access). Very practical for French speakers.

Lighter Reading

Title: “Why pronunciation matters more than grammar in business” (Short article)

Source: BBC Learning English or LinkedIn Learning blog

Bonus for fluency

Article: “How to stop saying ‘um’ and ‘ah’ in presentations”

Source: Toastmasters International (free tips page)

Why: Simple, actionable techniques.



The end of the course, but the start of your journey.
Best of luck in all your future projects!
Keep in touch.

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